Afterword

So that was how my journey was till Kargil. And what a journey it was—full of tough times, challenges, opportunities and adventures. There were times when I felt on top of the world and also when I wanted to give up, when I had doubts about myself. My heart and mind were seldom on a separate page but on every such occasion, I was able to align them in overcoming obstacles. To sum up, it was a journey full of learning.

Post Kargil, my life traversed a different path. I was posted to a helicopter unit in the North-east sector, which proved extremely lucky for me. There, I met my perfect match. I got married to Wing Commander Gautam Narain, a helicopter pilot of the Indian Air Force. We were blessed with a daughter, Pragya. She brought so much happiness into our world, which we never knew existed. Gautam and I started enjoying the roller-coaster ride that is parenthood. After my daughter was born, I decided to hang up my uniform. But, fortunately, my association with the Indian Air Force continued—as the spouse of an officer.

Even without adorning a uniform or occupying a cockpit, I felt part of the air force. I continued to interact with young officers and saw a positive change in their outlook—the whole organization was evolving and changing progressively towards accepting female officers. It has been a pleasure to witness the gradual change in the work profiles of female officers. It is heartening to see them hold key operational posts in the Indian Air Force, which we could only dream of when we joined the organization.

A frequently asked question to me, which I love to answer, is how I feel after having retired.

I cherish every single minute that I spent serving in the air force. Irrespective of how I felt while going through it, each experience, big or small, has made me what I am today. During my association with the air